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Episource is notifying
millions of people that
their health data was
stolen

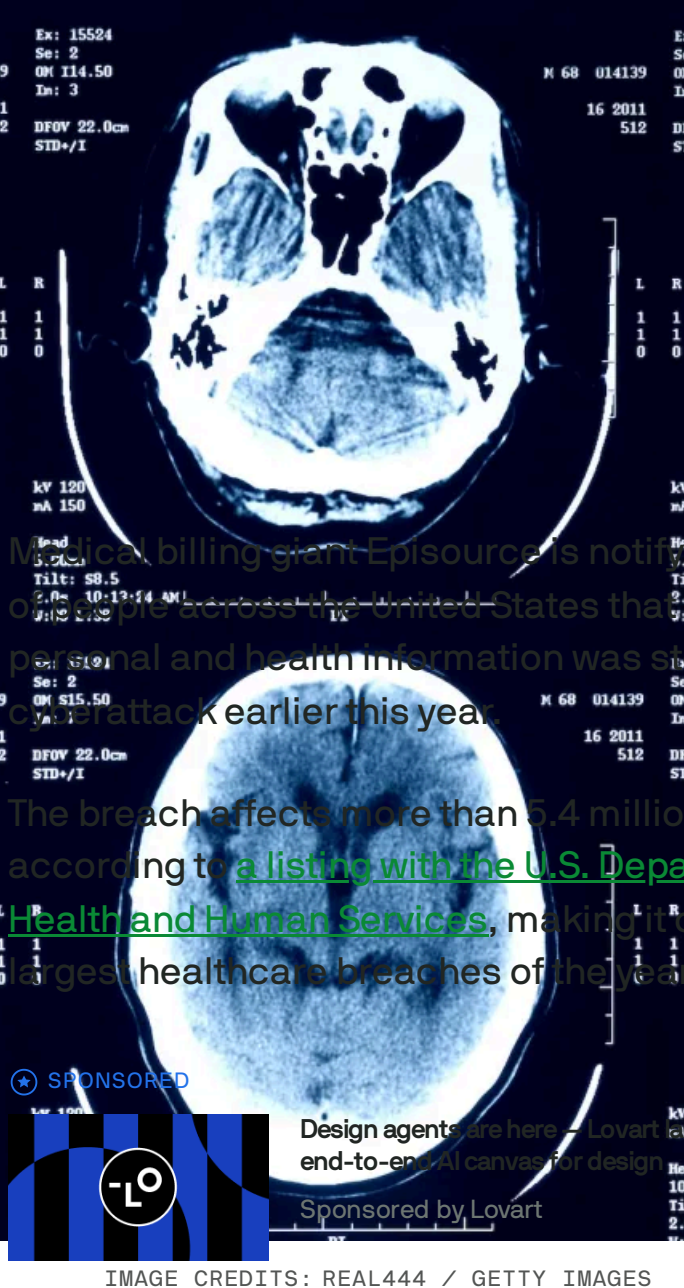


IMAGE CREDITS: REAL444 / GETTY IMAGES

Zack Whittaker — 12:07 PM PDT · July 14, 2025

Medical billing giant Episource is notifying millions of people across the United States that their personal and health information was stolen in a cyberattack earlier this year.

The breach affects more than 5.4 million people, according to a [listing with the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services](#), making it one of the largest healthcare breaches of the year so far.

Episource, owned by health insurance giant UnitedHealth Group’s subsidiary Optum, provides billing adjustment to the doctors, hospitals, and other organizations that work in the healthcare industry. As such, the company handles large amounts of patients’ personal and medical data to process claims through their health insurance.

In notices filed in [California](#) and [Vermont](#) on Friday, Episource said a criminal was able to “see and take copies” of patient and member data from its systems during the weeklong breach ending February 6.

The stolen information includes personal information, such as names, postal and email addresses, and phone numbers, as well as

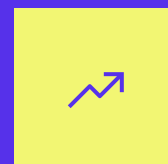
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protected health data, including medical record numbers, and data relating to doctors, diagnoses, medications, test results, imaging, care, and other treatment. The stolen data also contains health insurance information, like health plans, policies, and member numbers.

Episource did not describe the nature of the incident, but Sharp Healthcare, one of the companies that works with Episource and was affected by the cyberattack, told its customers that [the Episource hack was caused by ransomware](#).

This is the latest cybersecurity incident to hit UnitedHealth in recent years.

Change Healthcare, one of the largest companies in the U.S. healthcare industry that processes billions of health transactions each year, was [hacked by a ransomware gang in February 2024](#), leading to the theft of more than 190 million Americans' personal and health information. The cyberattack was the largest healthcare data breach in U.S. history.

Several months later, UnitedHealth's Optum unit left exposed to the internet [an internal chatbot](#) used by employees to ask about claims.

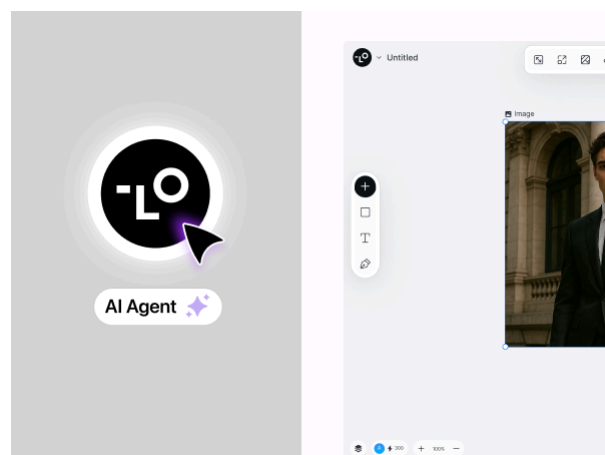
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UnitedHealth says
Change Healthcare hack
affects over 100 million,



the largest-ever US healthcare data breach

Zack Whittaker — 1:55 PM PDT · October 24, 2024

More than 100 million individuals had their private health information stolen during the ransomware attack on Change Healthcare in February, a cyberattack that caused months of unprecedented outages and widespread disruption across the U.S. healthcare sector.

This is the first time that UnitedHealth Group (UHG), the U.S. health insurance provider that owns the health tech company, has put a number of affected individuals to the data breach, after previously saying it anticipated the breach to include data on a “substantial proportion of people in America.”

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The U.S. Department of Health and Human Services first reported the updated number on its data breach portal on Thursday.

UHG spokesperson Tyler Mason said in a brief statement: “We continue to notify potentially impacted individuals as quickly as possible, on a rolling basis, given the volume and complexity of

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the data involved and the investigation is still in its final stages.”

The [ransomware attack](#) and data breach at Change Healthcare stands as the largest known digital theft of U.S. medical records, and [one of the biggest data breaches in living history](#). The ramifications for the millions of Americans whose private medical information was irretrievably stolen are likely to be life lasting.

UHG began notifying affected individuals in late July, which continued through October.

The stolen data varies by individual, but Change [previously confirmed that it includes personal information](#), such as names and addresses, dates of birth, phone numbers and email addresses, and government identity documents, including Social Security numbers, driver’s license numbers, and passport numbers. The stolen health data includes diagnoses, medications, test results, imaging and care and treatment plans, and health insurance information — as well as financial and banking information found in claims and payment data taken by the criminals.

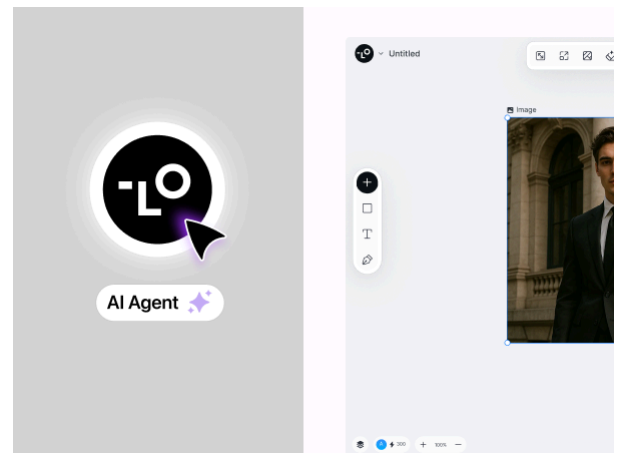
Change Healthcare is one of the largest handlers of health, medical data, and patient records, as it processes patient insurance and billing across the U.S. healthcare sector, including thousands of hospitals, pharmacies, and medical practices. As such, Change handles huge amounts of health and medical-related information on [around a third of all Americans](#), the company’s chief executive Andrew Witty told lawmakers in May.

The cyberattack [became public on February 21](#) when Change Healthcare pulled much of its network offline to contain the intruders, causing immediate outages across the U.S. healthcare

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sector that relied on Change for handling patient insurance and billing.

UHG attributed [the cyberattack to ALPHV/BlackCat](#), a Russian-speaking ransomware and extortion gang, which later took credit for the cyberattack.

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The ransomware gang's leaders later vanished after absconding with a \$22 million ransom paid by the health insurance giant, stiffing the group's contractors who carried out the hacking of Change Healthcare out of their new financial windfall. The contractors took the data they stole from Change Healthcare and formed a new group, which extorted a second ransom from UHG, while publishing a [portion of the stolen files online in the process to prove their threat](#).

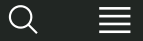
There is no evidence that the cybercriminals subsequently deleted the data. Other extortion gangs, [including LockBit](#), have been shown to hoard stolen data, [even after the victim pays and the criminals claim to have deleted the data](#).

In paying the ransom, Change [obtained a copy of the stolen dataset](#), allowing the company to identify and notify the affected individuals whose information was found in the data.

Efforts by the U.S. government to catch the hackers behind ALPHV/BlackCat, one of the most prolific ransomware gangs today, have so far failed. The gang [bounced back following a takedown operation in 2023](#) to seize the gang's dark web leak site.

Months after the Change Healthcare breach, the [U.S. State Department upped its reward for](#)

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During a House hearing into the cyberattack in April, UnitedHealth's CEO Witty confirmed that the cybercriminals broke into one of its employee systems using [stolen credentials that were not protected with multi-factor authentication](#) (MFA), a security feature that can help to protect against the misuse of password theft.

By gaining access to a critical internal system using only a stolen password, the ransomware gang was able to reach other parts of Change Healthcare's network and deploy ransomware.



UNITEDHEALTH CEO ANDREW WITTY TESTIFIES BEFORE THE SENATE FINANCE COMMITTEE ON CAPITOL HILL ON MAY 1, 2024, IN WASHINGTON, DC.

It's unclear why the system was not protected with MFA, but this will likely remain a key part of the ongoing investigations by lawmakers and the government. Witty told lawmakers that the organization has [since rolled out and now enforces MFA](#) following the cyberattack.

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Lawmakers homed in on how UHG handles so much data and generates so much revenue and failed at basic cybersecurity.

According to its 2023 full-year earnings report, UHG made \$22 billion in profit on revenues of \$371 billion. Witty made \$23.5 million in executive compensation the same year.

While the lack of MFA was abused in this case, the sheer size and wealth of highly sensitive data that Change Healthcare collects and stores made it a target in itself, [lawmakers said](#).

Change Healthcare merged with U.S. healthcare provider Optum in 2022 as part of a \$7.8 billion deal by UnitedHealth Group. The deal brought the two healthcare giants under UHG and allowed Optum, which owns physician groups and provides tech and data to insurance companies and healthcare services, broad access to patient records handled by Change.

UnitedHealth Group collectively provides over 53 million U.S. customers with benefit plans and another 5 million outside of the United States, according to [its latest full-year earnings report](#). Optum serves about 103 million U.S. customers.

The deal faced scrutiny by U.S. federal antitrust authorities, who [sued to block UHG from buying Change Healthcare and merging it with Optum](#), arguing that UnitedHealth would get an unfair competitive advantage by gaining access to “about half of all Americans’ health insurance claims pass each year.” A judge ultimately approved the deal.

The Justice Department reportedly began [cranking up its investigation into UHG](#) and its potential anticompetitive practices in the months prior to the Change Healthcare hack.

Updated with UHG comment.

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- [How the ransomware attack at Change Healthcare went down: A timeline](#)
- [Change Healthcare confirms ransomware hackers stole medical records on a ‘substantial proportion’ of Americans](#)
- [Change Healthcare hackers broke in using stolen credentials — and no MFA, says UHG CEO](#)

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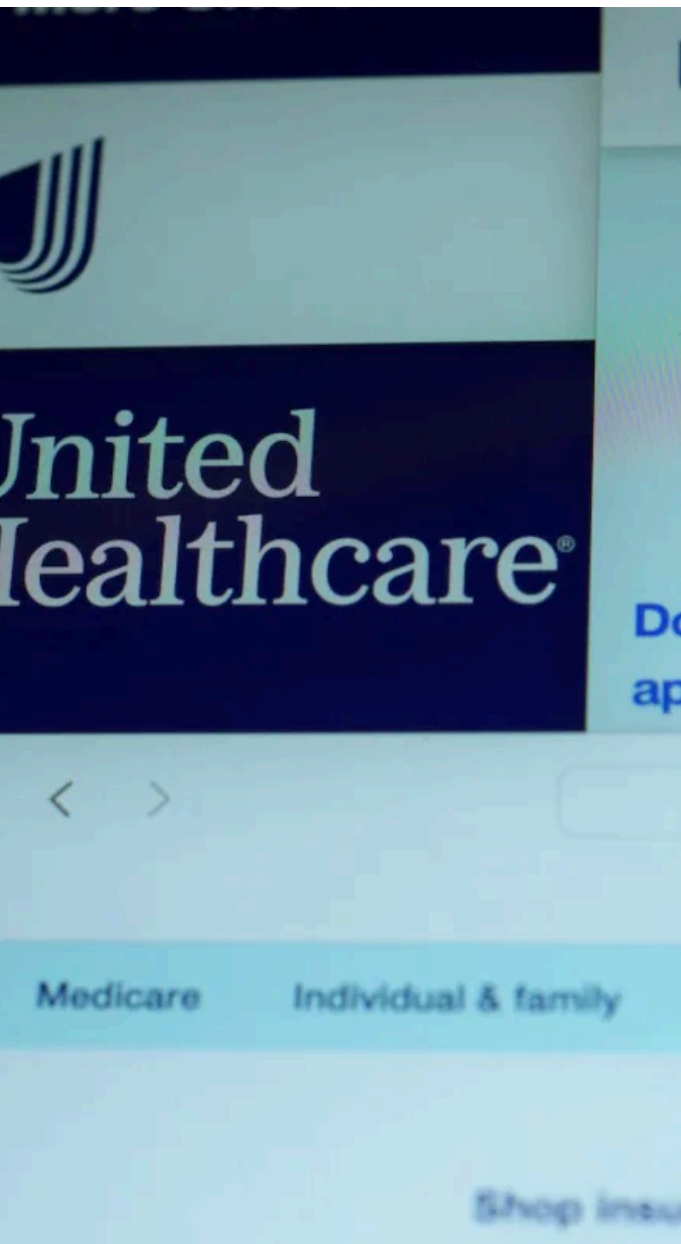


IMAGE CREDITS: PATRICK SISON / AP

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UnitedHealth confirms 190 million Americans affected by Change Healthcare data breach

Zack Whittaker — 3:16 PM PST · January 24, 2025

UnitedHealth has confirmed the ransomware attack on its Change Healthcare unit last February

affected around 190 million people in America — nearly double previous estimates.

The U.S. health insurance giant confirmed the latest number to TechCrunch on Friday after the markets closed.

“Change Healthcare has determined the estimated total number of individuals impacted by the Change Healthcare cyberattack is approximately 190 million,” said Tyler Mason, a spokesperson for UnitedHealth Group in an email to TechCrunch. “The vast majority of those people have already been provided individual or substitute notice. The final number will be confirmed and filed with the Office for Civil Rights at a later date.”

UnitedHealth’s spokesperson said the company was “not aware of any misuse of individuals’ information as a result of this incident and has not seen electronic medical record databases appear in the data during the analysis.”

The February 2024 cyberattack is the largest breach of medical data in U.S. history and caused months of outages across the U.S. healthcare system. Change Healthcare, a health tech giant and UnitedHealth subsidiary, is one of the largest handlers of health, medical data, and patient records; it’s also one of the biggest processors of healthcare claims in the United States.

The data breach resulted in [the theft of massive quantities of health and insurance-related information](#), some of which was published online by the hackers who claimed responsibility for the breach. Change Healthcare subsequently paid [at least two ransoms to prevent further publication](#) of the stolen files.

UnitedHealth previously [put the number of affected individuals](#) at around 100 million people when the

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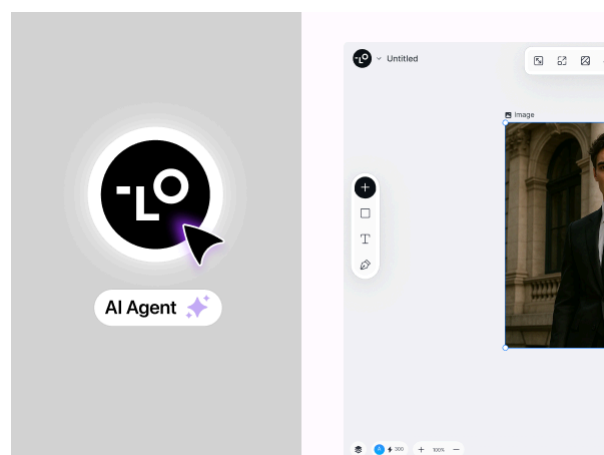
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company filed its preliminary analysis with the Office for Civil Rights, the unit under the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services that investigates data breaches.



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In its data breach notice, Change Healthcare said that the cybercriminals stole names and addresses, dates of birth, phone numbers, email addresses, and government identity documents, which included Social Security numbers, driver's license numbers, and passport numbers. The stolen health data also includes diagnoses, medications, test results, imaging, and care and treatment plans, as well as health insurance information. Change said the data also includes financial and banking information found in patient claims.

The breach was [attributed to the ALPHV ransomware gang](#), a prolific Russian language cybercrime group. According to testimony by UnitedHealth Group's CEO Andrew Witty to

lawmakers last year, the hackers broke into Change’s systems using a stolen account credential, which was [not protected with multi-factor authentication](#).

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